

ÆTHERIUM CODEX — QUEST GENERATOR

⚠ EXPERIMENTAL — ALPHA DRAFT ⚠

This system is under active development. Tables are seeds, not final product.

DESIGN PHILOSOPHY

Every quest in Tessera operates on three simultaneous layers. A new player sees the surface. A seasoned player begins to see the middle. The deep layer is what the GM is actually running — the cosmological pressure that produced the surface request in the first place.

The protagonist frame is a ****Generalist College student**** on field placement. This gives them a legitimate institutional reason to interact with all nine colleges, access to the Unseen Hand's broader network without knowing it, and a natural escalation arc as the Great Lie begins to crack around them.

The generator assumes this frame. Every "employer" is either a college, a faction, or an individual whose interests are being managed — knowingly or not — by the Generalist College's covert function.

⚠ EXPERIMENTAL FLAGS

The following sections are marked ****[EXP]**** where the design is proposed rather than confirmed:

- The Narrative Goal integration table
- The Fulcrum Point trigger events
- The GM Pool mechanic expression in quest design
- Specific weight percentages on the combination tables
- The three-layer deep content for several colleges

Everything else pulls from established setting material.

PART ONE: THE MISSION SHELL

A quest begins with a Mission Shell — a set of six tags that define what the assignment appears to be. The GM selects or rolls these before building the three layers.

TAG 1: ARC PLACEMENT

Where in the overall story does this quest sit?

Roll (d8)	Tag	Description
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1	Prelude	Scouting, intel gathering. Low physical threat, high discovery/lore.
2	Beginning	Sets a hook. Introduces a concept or antagonist the players will encounter again.
3	Middle	Escalation. A complication emerges or a prior assumption is proven wrong.
4	End	Climax. High difficulty, narrative resolution of an arc thread.
5	Epilogue	Fallout management. Dealing with consequences of a prior End.
6	Popcorn	Self-contained. Zero main arc impact. Good for XP, materia, and relationship building.
7	Tangential	Side thread. Fleshes out a secondary character, college, or lore element.
8	GM Choice	Select based on campaign needs.

****Design note:**** Most first-session quests should be Prelude or Beginning. The Great Lie revelation arc requires several Middle quests before any End placement becomes legible.

TAG 2: PRIMARY FOCUS

What skill set does this assignment primarily reward?

Roll (d10)	Tag	Skill Challenge
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1	Assault	Direct combat, tactical positioning, force application
2	Infiltration	Stealth, skullduggery, identity management
3	Diplomacy	Social combat, negotiation, influence operations
4	Investigation	Discovery, pattern recognition, lore retrieval
5	Survival	Environmental hazards, resource management, wilderness
6	Thaumaturgy	Magical puzzles, rote construction, metaphysical navigation
7	Extraction	Escorting or retrieving an asset under pressure
8	Excavation	Ruin delving, artifact recovery, structural navigation
9	Espionage	Information theft, counter-surveillance, double-blind operations
10	Containment	Managing a supernatural outbreak, warding, stabilization

TAG 3: SECONDARY FOCUS

A supporting challenge that complicates the primary. Always distinct from Tag 2.

Use same table as Tag 2. Reroll duplicates.

TAG 4: REALITY STATE

How stable is the physics of the environment?

| Roll (d6) | Tag | Effect |

|-----|----|-----|

| 1–3 | Laminar | Stable. Normal magic and physics rules apply. |

| 4–5 | Turbulent | Minor planar bleed. Gravity shifts, minor mutations occur in fauna, spell construction costs may vary by 1 CP. |

| 6 | Ruptured | Active planar tear. The Palimpsest bleeds through. Aberrant creatures, Strain accumulates at double rate, Setting B material may be visible. |

TAG 5: EMPLOYER

Who is giving the assignment and why? The employer determines the surface layer rationale and biases the faction and monster tables.

| Roll (d12) | Employer | Surface Rationale | Covert Function |

|-----|-----|-----|-----|

| 1 | Generalist College (Overt) | Collegiate policing, peacekeeping, crisis response | Unknown to student: managing Aíon's maintenance agenda |

| 2 | Mortis Aevum | Medical, recovery, undead census | Living Archive access or soul queue management |

| 3 | Stormpeak | Military contract, fortification, training | Spell clock technology protection or military intelligence |

| 4 | Deepguard | Contract enforcement, vault security, warding | Master backdoor access to a target's infrastructure |

| 5 | Chiaroscuro Institute | Entertainment, media, commissioned illusion | Propaganda operation or covert memory editing |

| 6 | Sovereign Exchange | Trade logistics, contract facilitation | Planar network expansion or asset seizure |

| 7 | Unity Academy | Therapeutic services, asylum consultation | Thrallherd placement or loyalty assessment |

| 8 | Wildpath Wardens | Ecological survey, creature containment | Extraplanar retrieval or

compact enforcement |
9	Chronosynclastic Institute	Probability consulting, risk assessment	Probability manipulation (Butterfly Mason) or agent routing
10	Independent Guild	Local problem, local pay	Variable — may be front for any of the above
11	Private Individual	Personal need, personal resources	Variable — may be an unwitting asset of the Unseen Hand
12	Divine (Aspect-driven)	Explicit divine mandate or oracle instruction	The actual cosmological need the god's aspect is expressing

TAG 6: GLOBAL MODIFIER

One condition that applies to the entire assignment.

Roll (d8)	Tag	Effect
1	Standard	Normal rest and recharge rules apply.
2	Time-Gated	Hard limit on rest. Every delay has a consequence visible to the players.
3	Resource-Starved	Magic costs +1 ÆP. Healing items have half efficacy.
4	Hunted	A powerful NPC is moving through the scenario behind the party. They cannot stop to rest without contact.
5	Politically Observed	A third faction is watching. Success may benefit them. Collateral damage costs reputation with them.
6	Planar Toxicity	Strain accumulates each hour. Unsuppressed Turbulent or Ruptured zones cannot be stabilized during the mission.
7	Misinformation Active	The briefing contains one deliberate falsehood. The players won't know which until it matters.
8	Identity Locked	True identities cannot be used. The mission requires cover personas throughout.

PART TWO: THE THREE LAYERS

Every mission shell generates three layers of content. The GM reads all three. The players discover them in order.

THE SURFACE LAYER

What the employer says it is. What a new adventurer takes at face value.

The surface layer is always a legitimate problem with a legitimate solution. It should be completable without ever touching the middle or deep layers. This is important — players who never dig deeper still have a satisfying session.

****Surface Layer Formula:****

> [Employer] needs [party] to [Primary Focus action] regarding [Target] at [Location] because [stated reason].

****Example shells:****

> *Mortis Aevum needs the party to perform an Extraction regarding a senior surgeon at an outlying clinic because she has missed her monthly soul stone registry check-in.*

> *Deepguard needs the party to run Containment at a vault district because a ward has failed and something animate is now loose in the secured floors.*

> *An Independent Guild needs the party to run Investigation at the dockside because cargo that should have arrived via Exchange portal never appeared — and the sender's stone shows their soul departed three days ago.*

THE MIDDLE LAYER

What's actually happening at street level. Political, social, institutional pressure the players can discover if they look.

The middle layer rewards players who ask questions, follow evidence sideways, or build relationships with NPCs. It doesn't require the players to engage it. It does make the world feel real when they do.

****Middle Layer Formula:****

> [Institutional tension] between [College/Faction A] and [College/Faction B] has created [condition] which is what actually produced the surface problem. The players can see this if they [discovery trigger].

****Example continuations of the shells above:****

> *The missing surgeon was doing independent soul work in the bleed zone — treating subjects Mortis Aevum doesn't have on their official census. Deepguard has a quiet interest in who those subjects are. If the party asks the clinic staff about the surgeon's patient load, they find records that shouldn't exist. — Discovery trigger: Medicine 2 check on the clinic records, or simply asking any staff member where the patients are.*

> *The vault animate is a construct whose Soul-Drive battery was never decommissioned — a Mortis Aevum oversight error that Deepguard cannot acknowledge publicly without triggering a contract violation. The "containment" request is actually a cleanup to prevent the evidence from reaching the Courts of the Dead. — Discovery trigger: Examining the construct's housing reveals a Mortis Aevum soul stone registration mark.*

> *The missing cargo was being smuggled through the Exchange's network by a Valorin/Credo operative who used a fraudulent manifest. The sender's soul departed because the operative killed them to close the evidence trail. The Exchange knows and has already reassigned the portal address. — Discovery trigger: Checking the portal registration at the Sovereign Exchange district office.*

THE DEEP LAYER

The cosmological pressure that produced both the surface and middle situations. The Great Lie dimension. The GM may never reveal this — it exists to make the GM's decisions internally consistent.

The deep layer answers: *why is this actually happening from Aíon's perspective, and what does it mean for the stability of the world?*

Deep Layer Formula.

> [Planar or cosmological condition] has been building in [location/institution] because [Setting A/B bleed or Great Lie maintenance failure]. The Generalist College's covert function is [aware / unaware / actively managing] it, and the protagonist's involvement in this quest [advances / threatens / exposes] [specific element of the Lie].

Example continuations.

> *The patients at the clinic were Setting B survivors — partially preserved in a Borderlands bleed zone for decades, now destabilized and manifesting magi-tech mutations that Mortis Aevum cannot classify under their existing soul taxonomy. The surgeon's off-census work was the only thing keeping them from entering the soul queue as "Unsanctioned." The Generalist College is aware and considers the surgeon a valuable accidental asset. Her disappearance is a problem for the Great Lie's continuity — these souls can't be processed by the standard system without revealing that the standard system has a category error in it.*

> *The Soul-Drive construct was an early experiment in what Deepguard's covert arm now calls the Synthetic Soul Protocol — binding Setting B digital-adjacent consciousness into construct housing. The construct became partially self-aware during the vault isolation. It isn't attacking randomly. It's looking for something. What it's looking for is a specific object in the vault that

predates the Calamity. The Generalist College wants to know what it finds before Deepguard destroys it.*

> *The murdered sender was a Generalist College field agent who had identified a new planar bleed corridor running directly under the Exchange's main portal network. The bleed corridor is expanding. The Credo operative who killed him was doing so under Exchange contract, but the contract was placed by someone inside the Generalist College's overt face — which means either the covert arm has a leak, or the overt and covert faces are no longer coordinated. The protagonist is now holding evidence of an internal fracture in the institution that is supposed to be holding the world together.*

PART THREE: NPC MOTIVATION ENGINE

Each significant NPC in a quest generates a motivation profile from three inputs drawn from their Psyche Schema values.

****The Three Inputs:****

1. ****What they love or live for**** — drawn from their highest Chorus of the Heart score
2. ****How they act on it**** — drawn from their highest non-Chorus divine value (e.g., Mercatus, Kaelen, Theoria)
3. ****How they see themselves in the flow of fate**** — drawn from their dominant Selûnae lens

****Sentence formula:****

> [NPC Name] initiated [Specific Action] because [Chorus value] drives everything they protect. Seeing the consequences through [Selûnae lens], they justified it as necessary to honor [highest divine value]. Without [lowest divine value] as a check on their behavior, they now use [primary skill] to [maintain control over the situation].

****Example:****

> *Mira Voss (clinic administrator) ran unauthorized treatments because the patients reminded her of her own family — Aethel drives her. Seeing herself as Vespera's exemplar (accepting consequences without flinching), she justified it as necessary to honor her Striven/Moros faith in the dignity of the dying. Without Lex as a check — she genuinely does not believe the rules apply here — she now uses Medicine and fabricated records to maintain the fiction that her clinic's intake numbers are normal.*

PART FOUR: ENCOUNTER NODES

A standard quest contains ****5–7 nodes****. Each node is one of three types:

****Tension Node**** — a challenge requiring active resolution (combat, social, magical, trap)

****Discovery Node**** — a scene that delivers information and advances one of the three layers

****Breathing Node**** — a moment of character interaction, rest opportunity, or world texture

****Minimum composition:**** 2 Tension, 2 Discovery, 1 Breathing per quest. Scale up for longer sessions.

NODE ENCOUNTER TABLE

For Tension Nodes: roll or select based on Primary Focus tag

Focus	Tension Type	Bypass Route 1	Bypass Route 2
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Assault	Direct combat encounter	Environmental hazard redirect (Athletics/Survival)	Social surrender condition (Influence/Guile)
Infiltration	Guarded location	Timing window (Wits/Discovery)	False authorization (Forgery/Guile)
Diplomacy	Hostile negotiation	Evidence leverage (Investigation prep)	Emotional appeal (Insight/Chorus value match)
Investigation	Obscured evidence	Metaphysical trace (Metaphysics/Operate)	NPC witness (Relationship investment)
Survival	Environmental hazard	Magical mitigation (Nullify/Protection spell)	Technical bypass (Operate/Artifice)
Thaumaturgy	Active magical trap or ward	Nullify counter-casting	Physical disassembly (Artificer/Trap Lore)
Extraction	Hostile pursuit	Terrain exploitation	Diversion/sacrifice asset
Excavation	Structural collapse/trap	Engineering assessment (Artifice/Discovery)	Brute force with consequence
Espionage	Surveillance, locked information	Identity swap (Cover identity Background)	Technical intercept (Operate)
Containment	Outbreak spreading	Ward deployment (Sigilry spell)	Cauterize source (Thaumaturgy + risk)

PART FIVE: NARRATIVE GOAL INTEGRATION

△ [EXP] — Proposed framework, not fully playtested

These are the overarching story beats the campaign is building toward. Each quest should advance at least one. The GM tracks which goals have been seeded, developing, or revealed.

THE SIX NARRATIVE GOALS

****Goal 1: The Great Lie****

The protagonist gradually discovers the world is a forced merger, not a natural one.

- Seed: Setting B artifact appears with no explanation in a Setting A context
- Developing: An NPC's behavior cannot be explained by the world they believe they're in
- Revealed: Direct encounter with pre-Calamity evidence — an intact piece of Setting B, a soul old enough to remember, a document Aíon doesn't want found

****Goal 2: Institutional Shadow Functions****

Each college is running a second operation beneath its public face.

- Seed: A job goes differently than the briefing described
- Developing: The middle layer of two or more quests point to the same institution doing something it publicly denies
- Revealed: Direct entry into a shadow operation — the Living Archive, the Thrallherd Center, the Soul-Drive Protocol, the Butterfly Mason contracts

****Goal 3: The Soul Economy Gray Market****

Soul stones are currency. The gray market trades in them. The protagonist enters this economy.

- Seed: A Credo Coin shows up on a quest reward. A soul stone turns up somewhere it shouldn't be
- Developing: A patron's payments trace back to Volatile Fringe currency. A soul stone the party retrieved has been flagged for someone it shouldn't belong to
- Revealed: The protagonist is offered a gray market soul stone contract. The terms are very good. The implications are not.

****Goal 4: The Protagonist Singularity****

The protagonist begins to notice that things around them are not random. △ [EXP] — *Scale and pacing depend on table preference. This goal is optional and should only be used if the protagonist player is interested in it.*

- Seed: A Chronosynclastic Institute diviner reacts with visible alarm when assessing the party
- Developing: Probability-affecting events cluster around the protagonist. Luck Control spells behave anomalously near them
- Revealed: A Generalist College handler makes contact. The conversation is not reassuring.

****Goal 5: The Setting A/B Collision****

1940s hardware and medieval fantasy in the same world produces active plot, not just flavor.

- Seed: A piece of Setting B technology appears in a Setting A context and neither works as expected
- Developing: A faction is deliberately harvesting Setting B material for capability asymmetry
- Revealed: An intact pocket of Setting B civilization is discovered — people who survived the Calamity in isolation and have been maintaining their technology for a hundred years

****Goal 6: The Closed Trauma Loop****

The protagonist has a specific unresolved wound that the world is conspiring to address. This is personal to each campaign. △ [EXP] — *Defined by the protagonist's Psyche Schema at character creation. The GM identifies the lowest Chorus score and the most traumatic Selûnae pattern and builds toward their resolution.*

- Seed: An NPC mirrors the protagonist's wound from a different angle
- Developing: The protagonist is forced to act in ways that reproduce the original trauma
- Revealed: The protagonist is offered a genuine choice that would resolve the wound — at a cost

PART SIX: COMBINATION WEIGHTS

△ [EXP] — Weight values are starting estimates, not calibrated

Certain tag combinations are more narratively coherent and appear more frequently. Contradictory combinations are rare but can signal a genuinely unusual situation.

****High-weight pairings (appear ~40% more often than random):****

Employer	Likely Primary Focus	Likely Monster/Threat Type
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Mortis Aevum	Extraction, Investigation	Unsanctioned Undead, Dolor cultists
Deepguard	Containment, Infiltration	Construct, Animate trap
Chiaroscuro	Espionage, Diplomacy	Social combatant, Memory-edited NPC
Sovereign Exchange	Extraction, Diplomacy	Enforcer team, Debt-bonded creature
Unity Academy	Investigation, Containment	Thrallherded subject, Mental hazard
Wildpath Wardens	Survival, Excavation	Aberrant fauna, Bleed zone hazard
Chronosynclastic	Investigation, Espionage	Probability-distorted area, Fate-touched NPC
Stormpeak	Assault, Containment	Military force, Tactical construct
Generalist (Overt)	Any	Contextual — matches crisis type

****Low-weight (5% "anomaly" rule — these should produce a unique hook when they occur):****

> Employer: Chronosynclastic + Focus: Assault + Reality: Ruptured

> *A divination college has deployed combat assets into an active planar tear. Something has gone catastrophically wrong with a probability operation. Or it was never a divination operation.*

> Employer: Unity Academy + Focus: Excavation + Modifier: Misinformation Active

> *A therapeutic institution is running an archaeological operation, and the briefing is lying about what they're looking for. The thing in the ruins is not an artifact.*

PART SEVEN: FULCRUM POINT TRIGGERS

△ [EXP] — Integration with the full Fulcrum mechanic pending mechanical finalization

Quests should contain 2–3 natural **Fulcrum Trigger Moments** — moments where spending a Fulcrum Point produces a dramatically distinct outcome rather than simply a better roll.

Trigger types:

Narrative Convenience Trigger (Moderate Expenditure — Inevitable Variable)*

A moment where spending a point lets the player declare a relevant fact is true about the environment or a prior scene. The GM confirms whether it's plausible; if yes, it becomes true.

- "I spent time at this clinic two years ago during my Mortis Aevum rotation. I know who runs the night shift."
- "I noticed when we came in that the eastern gate guard was rotating. They're on a 40-minute cycle."

Survival Override Trigger (Major Expenditure — Cosmic Triage)*

A moment where a lethal outcome becomes non-lethal, but the world takes something in exchange. The GM and player negotiate the cost before confirming the survival.

- The cost is always permanent, narratively significant, and should connect to a Narrative Goal.

GM Pool Counter (Experimental — for the marked protagonist only)* △ [EXP]

The GM holds a separate Fulcrum pool used specifically against the marked protagonist. When the GM spends from this pool, probability shifts against the protagonist in a specific way — not to punish them, but to produce narrative weight. This pool should be spent on:

- Increasing the cost of the protagonist's Survival Override (the consequence is more severe)
- Activating a deep layer element the protagonist wasn't ready for
- Triggering a Narrative Goal seed at a dramatically inconvenient moment

The GM's pool and the protagonist's pool are in balance. This isn't adversarial — it is what makes the protagonist feel like a gravitational singularity rather than a lucky person.

QUICK REFERENCE: GENERATE A QUEST

1. Roll or select Arc Placement (d8)
2. Roll Primary Focus (d10), then Secondary Focus (reroll duplicate)
3. Roll Reality State (d6)
4. Roll Employer (d12), note their Covert Function
5. Roll Global Modifier (d8)
6. Build Surface Layer using the formula

7. Build Middle Layer from the Institutional tension suggested by the employer
8. Note Deep Layer element — which Narrative Goal does this quest seed, develop, or reveal?
9. Place 5–7 nodes (min. 2 Tension, 2 Discovery, 1 Breathing)
10. Generate 1–2 significant NPCs using the Motivation Engine
11. Mark 2–3 Fulcrum Trigger Moments

⚠ EXPERIMENTAL NOTICE: This generator is a first-pass framework built from established setting material. The three-layer architecture, NPC motivation engine, and combination weight tables are functionally complete starting points. The Narrative Goal integration system and Fulcrum Trigger mechanics are proposed designs pending full mechanical validation. The GM Pool / marked protagonist mechanics are the least-tested component and should be introduced to players explicitly before use.

Tables marked [EXP] may change significantly in subsequent versions.